

JOHN W. BARRY

January 2026

Rice University
6100 Main Street MS 531
Houston, TX 77005

Email: john.w.barry@rice.edu
Office: (+1) 713-348-6242
Mobile: (+1) 346-228-2292
Web: <https://johnwbarry.info/>

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Rice University	Houston, TX
Assistant Professor of Finance	2024-

EDUCATION

Duke University, Fuqua School of Business	Durham, NC
PhD, Finance	2018-2024
Barcelona School of Economics	Barcelona, Spain
MS, International Trade, Finance and Development (ITFD)	2015-2016
Trinity College Dublin	Dublin, Ireland
BA, Philosophy, Politics, Economics & Sociology (PPES)	2009-2013

WORKING PAPERS

Human Capital, Competition and Mobility in the Managerial Labor Market

with Noah Lyman and Lin Zhao (December 2025) [Latest version, SSRN](#)

We pose a structural model of the managerial labor market with general and firm-specific human capital accumulation, managerial bargaining power, and imperfect labor market competition. Empirically, firm-specific skill drives wage growth and variability over careers; it also restricts mobility and helps explain the low rate of external CEO hiring. We decouple bargaining power from labor market competition in managerial rent extraction, with competition accounting for a substantial share, especially for poached CEOs. Firm-specific skill accumulation increases match productivity between firms and managers, shaping the dynamics of rent extraction by raising rent growth over tenure while dampening it over experience.

Shareholder Voice and Executive Compensation

(January 2026) [Latest version, SSRN](#)

I estimate a model of CEO compensation with nonbinding shareholder approval votes (Say-on-Pay): shareholders can dissent on compensation decisions and punish the Board. Because the compensation proposal is endogenous to the voting environment itself, the threat of dissent disciplines pay ex ante and increases shareholder value by 2.97% on average, despite a 6% failure rate. I analyze counterfactual vote designs that alter the intervention and communication aspects of the vote. Binding votes pin pay to the last approved policy and may ignore new information about CEO ability. Designs that strengthen intervention while incorporating vote-revealed information may best benefit shareholders.

Hurdle Rate Buffers and Bargaining Power in Asset Acquisition

with Bruce Carlin, Alan Crane and John Graham (July 2025) [SSRN](#)

Conditionally Accepted at the Journal of Financial Economics

CFOs report using elevated hurdle rates that average 6.6 percentage points above the cost of capital. We show that hurdle rate buffers act as a commitment device and convey a bargaining advantage over counterparties during project development and M&A. This benefit can exceed the opportunity cost of forgone projects and acquisitions, preserving firm value. Consistent with our model, bidders' elevated hurdle rates in M&A deals associate with higher surplus capture ex post; in CFO survey data, hurdle rate buffers negatively relate to ex ante bargaining power, and realized returns cluster just above elevated hurdle rates.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Information and Preferences in Shareholder Voting

with James Pinnington and Lin Zhao (January 2026)

Executive Mobility in the United States, 1920-2023

with John Graham, Hyunseob Kim and Dawoon Kim (January 2026)

PUBLICATIONS

Corporate Flexibility in a Time of Crisis

with Murillo Campello, John Graham and Yueran Ma (June 2022)

[Journal of Financial Economics](#)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

- 2025:** SWFA, ITAM Finance Conference, Univ. Amsterdam, IAF, FIRS, UNSW Corporate Finance, NBER Economics of Executive Compensation, FMA (×2), Berlin Labor & Finance[†]
- 2024:** Toulouse School of Economics, CEMFI, Cornell University, Notre Dame University, Rice University, Ohio State University, UMass Amherst, MIT Sloan, Boston College, University of Maryland, Vanderbilt University, UVA Darden, MFA, Eastern Finance, Aarhus Strategic Interactions Workshop, Lone Star Finance Symposium, UTD Finance Conference
- 2023:** AFA, LBS TADC, Inter-Finance PhD Seminar, Duke IO lunch, Fuqua, Olin Finance Conference PhD Poster Session, Boca Finance Conference [†]= scheduled

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor	Rice University
Advanced Corporate Finance (Undergraduate)	2025-
Advanced Corporate Finance (MBA)	2025-
Head Teaching Assistant	Duke University
Corporate Finance (MBA)	2019-2023
Empirical Methods in Corporate Finance (PhD)	2019-2023
Pre-PhD	International House Dublin & Huelva
English Teacher	2013-2015

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Referee: Journal of Finance, Review of Financial Studies, Review of Finance, Management Science, Journal of Corporate Finance, Financial Management, American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Human capital